2026 Winter Games Team USA Opening Ceremonies Hat

January 2026: Reverse Engineered by Susan Rainey of the Rainey Sisters
lv2knit on Ravelry, lv2knitmn on Instagram, [The Rainey Sisters Blog]

Every attempt has been made to provide an error-free pattern, but if you find any mistakes, please contact me on Ravelry (lv2knit).

Team USA Hat for the 2026 Winter Games

I have reverse engineered the last couple of winter Olympics hats and was asked if I planned on doing it again. Here is the result. Photos of the original are on page 9.

Sizes and yarn quantities are estimates. Knitters vary, gauge varies, people's heads vary!!

Hat: Sizes vary based on stitch count and needle size. Four options are possible:
Size small (17"): small/medium chart (8 repeats) and smaller needles
Size medium (18"): small/medium chart (8 repeats) and larger needles
Size large (19"): large/extra large chart (9 repeats) and smaller needles
Size extra large (20"): large/extra large chart (9 repeats) and larger needles

Yarn: Worsted weight yarn in dark navy, bright red, and winter white
For the sample I used Cascade 220 (Navy 8393 ~60 grams, Red 8895 ~20 grams, Natural 8010, ~20 grams). There is some waste with making the tassels, etc.

Needles:

Needle Sizes			
	Larger Needles	Smaller Needles	Your Size if Different
i-cord	6	5	
Ribbing	7	6	
Plain Color Rounds	7	6	
Stranded Rnds	8	7	
Crown shaping	7	6	
DPNs for crown	7	6	

Gauge: Approx. 21 sts and 28 rows over stranded colorwork using US 8 needle
12-stitch stranded repeat is approx. 2 ¼ inches wide. Smaller needle yields a slightly tighter gauge.
NOTE: if you knit ribbing loosely, consider going down a needle size.

Abbreviations – see page 6

Hat Construction

The hat is started by making two earflaps which begin with i-cord. The earflaps are joined by casting on additional sts between the earflaps. The hat continues with ribbing and then stranded knitting. I refer to the larger needle sizes throughout, but keep track of the needles that you use to obtain gauge or size.

The stitch counts change a couple of times to minimize the jog. The last repeat of the chart is different from the first repeats in order to minimize the jog. Use yarn tails and fudging to help correct the jog!

I edited a couple of rows to remove 3-color stranding. I thought I had removed all 3-color rows until I got to round 14! I did not change rnds 14 & 16 as doing so would have changed the design too much. I have included the original chart at the end if you want 100% authenticity!

Start Hat -- To make hat without earflaps, cast on 104 (112) sts. If you do start with the ribbing, consider going down another needle size. The earflap version fits a bit looser around the brim.

Earflaps (make two)

Using navy blue and two size 6 dpns, cast on 4 sts, leaving a long tail. Work 6 inches of i-cord. Write down number of rows worked: _____

How to Knit I-Cord:

Cast on 4 sts. K4, slide these sts to other end of dpn. K4 (yarn will be coming out of the 4th st when you start). Eventually the knitting will form a tube. Continue until desired length is reached.

Start Flap:

Change to size 7 needle for earflaps. **After a few rows, mark RS with a pin.**

Row 1 (RS): k2, BLCO, k2 (5 sts)
Row 2 (WS): sl2 WYIF, p1, sl2 WYIF
Row 3: k2, YO, k1, YO, k2 (7 sts)
Row 4: sl2 WYIF, k1 TBL, p1, k1 TBL, sl2 WYIF
Row 5: k2, YO, p1, k1, p1, YO, k2 (9 sts)
Row 6: sl2 WYIF, p1 TBL, k1, p1, k1, p1 TBL, sl2 WYIF
Row 7: k2, YO, (k1, p1) to last 3 sts, k1, YO, k2 (11 sts) ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐
Row 8: sl2 WYIF, k1 TBL, (p1, k1) to last 4 sts, p1, k1 TBL, sl2 WYIF ☐ ☐ ☐
Row 9: k2, YO, (p1, k1) to last 3 sts, p1, YO, k2 (13 sts) ☐ ☐ ☐
Row 10: sl2 WYIF, p1 TBL, (k1, p1) to last 4 sts, k1, p1 TBL, sl2 WYIF ☐ ☐ ☐

Repeat rows 7-10 an additional 3 times (check boxes to keep track). Work row 7 once more (27 sts). Cut yarn. Make two. NOTE: for larger size, work two additional rows as set without increases.

Join Earflaps and Cast on Hat Sts (sz 7 needle): Using navy yarn and cable cast on method, cast on 11 (13) sts. Turn work so cast on sts are held in your righthand. Take one of the earflaps and hold it in your left hand with the WS facing. Slip last cast on st from RH needle to LH needle. P2tog. Then continue to work across first flap as follows, making sure to twist the YOs created in final Row 7: p1, k1tbl, (p1, k1) to last 4 sts, p1, k1 TBL, p2. For larger size, there will not be YOs to twist if two additional rows are worked.

Turn work so RS is facing. Cast on 30 (34) sts for front of hat. Turn work and join second earflap as you did the first by purling first st tog with last cast on st. Cont across second flap as above: p1, k1tbl, (p1, k1) to last 4 sts, p1, k1 TBL, p2. Turn work so RS is facing. Cast on 12 (14) sts. Join to work in the round by making sure your knitting is not twisted. Slip 1st cast on st from RH needle to LH needle. Pass last cast on st over the first; return st to RH needle. Place BOR marker. This is the center back of the hat. Each earflap is 27 sts, front of hat is 29 (33) sts, back of hat is 21 (25) sts. Total stitch count [104 (112) sts] Check your stitch count!

Work (k1, p1) ribbing for **1 inch** (the earflap ribbing and new cast on sts should line up so ribbing is continuous). Knit one row plain and **at same time** decrease as follows:

NOTE: this plain round counts as round 1 of Chart A.

Small/Medium (dec 7 sts): k6, (dec, k13) x 6, dec, k6. (97 sts)

Large/XL (dec 3 sts): (k35, dec) x 2, knit to last 2 sts, dec (109 sts)

Dec = decrease =

Use SSK if next st on LH needle is a knit st;

Use k2tog if next st on LH needle is a purl st

Charts start on Page 7. Use Charts A & C for the Small/Medium sizes, Charts B & C for L/XL.

Start Chart A for Small/Medium (Chart B for L/XL): Start with rnd 2 on chart. All chart rounds are read from right to left. Note: I switched to a larger needle to work the stranded rounds, and back to a size smaller for plain rnds. This change accounts for gauge differences between stranded and plain rows. However, this adjustment is knitter dependent. Note which needle sizes you are using!! Write this down on page one.

Remember, the last repeat is different than the first repeats in order to minimize the jog. It may be helpful to add a marker for the last repeat that is different than the BOR marker. Stitch counts change because of the jog adjustment. Complete through Round 28. [97 (107) sts remain]

Next Round: continue with navy and work one plain round, **decreasing as follows**:

Small/Medium: (k7, k2tog) x 1, (k6, k2tog) x 2, then (k10, k2tog) x 5, (k6, k2tog) x 1, k4. (88 sts).
Large/XL: (k5, k2tog) x 1, [(k6, k2tog, k10, k2tog) x 2, k6, k2tog] x 2, k4. (96 sts).

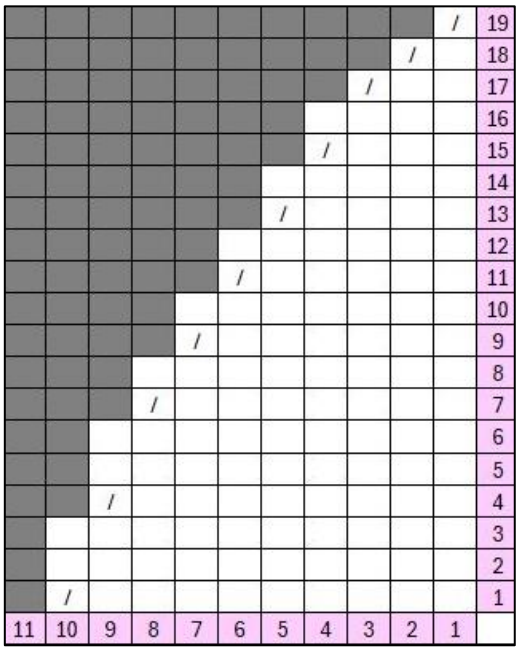
Work **Chart C** (both sizes):
Before knitting Chart C, the hat should measure about 5 ½ inches to the cast on edge. If your hat is getting too long, you can adjust here by omitting Chart C, or just working rows 1 & 2, or 1 & 3.

Crown Shaping

Continue in navy with smaller needle. Knit 2 plain rounds and then start crown shaping for your size. Switch to dpns when the stitch count warrants. The finished crown will add about 3 inches to the overall height of the hat. Cut yarn, leaving a generous tail. Pull yarn tail through remaining sts and tighten to close. Do not trim tail – it will be used to secure the top tassel. Continue next page **Finish Hat**.

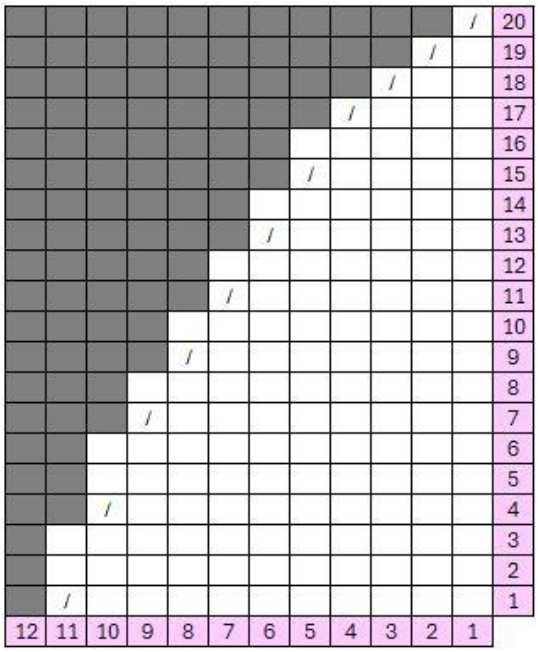
Small/Medium Crown Shaping

(k9, k2tog) x 8
K 2 rnds
(k8, k2tog) x 8
K 2 rnds
(k7, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k6, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnds
(k5, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k4, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k3, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k2, k2tog) x 8
(k1, k2tog) x 8
K2tog x 8



Large/XL Crown Shaping

(k10, k2tog) x 8
K 2 rnds
(k9, k2tog) x 8
K 2 rnds
(k8, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k7, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k6, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnds
(k5, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k4, k2tog) x 8
K 1 rnd
(k3, k2tog) x 8
(k2, k2tog) x 8
(k1, k2tog) x 8
K2tog x 8



Cut yarn, leaving a generous tail. Pull yarn tail through remaining sts and tighten to close. Do not trim tail – it will be used to secure the top tassel.

Finish Hat

Weave in ends. Wetblock before adding final tassels and top i-cord embellishments.

Tassels and Embellishments – NOTE: my original pattern shows tassels with little "heads" on them. The actual hat does not have these heads. To make the tassels without the head, see note after tassel instructions. Knitter's choice which to do!!

Make 4 small tassels (see next page). I used a 2 ½ inch piece of cardboard and did 30 wraps for each tassel. Sew a tassel onto the end of each earflap i-cord. With red, tightly wrap the i-cord above the tassel for about 1-¼ to 1-½ inches. I wrapped three layers of red to get the thickness needed. Put the yarn tails through a needle and secure them by pulling them underneath the wraps. It may take a bit of practice to get the wraps the way you want them.

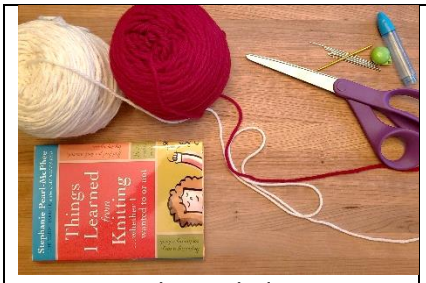
For top tassels: Make a length of i-cord about 10 inches long. Add tassels to each end as described above. Fold the
i-cord in half and mark the center. Sew to top of hat at the center. Whew! It's done!

Headless Tassels. Make tassels as described, but stop after Step 4. Do not wrap the tassel. Use the ties to sew the tassel to i-cord. Use red to wrap both the top of the tassel and part of the i-cord.

Abbreviations:

K2tog	knit 2 together (right leaning decrease)	Sl2	slip 2 sts as to purl
SSK	slip, slip, knit (left leaning decrease)	TBL	through back loop
BLCO	backward loop cast on (aka e-loop)	LH	left hand
dpn	double pointed needle	RH	right hand
rnd(s)	round(s)	RS	right side
BOR	beginning of round	WS	wrong side
WYIF	with yarn in front	m1	make 1 with your preferred method

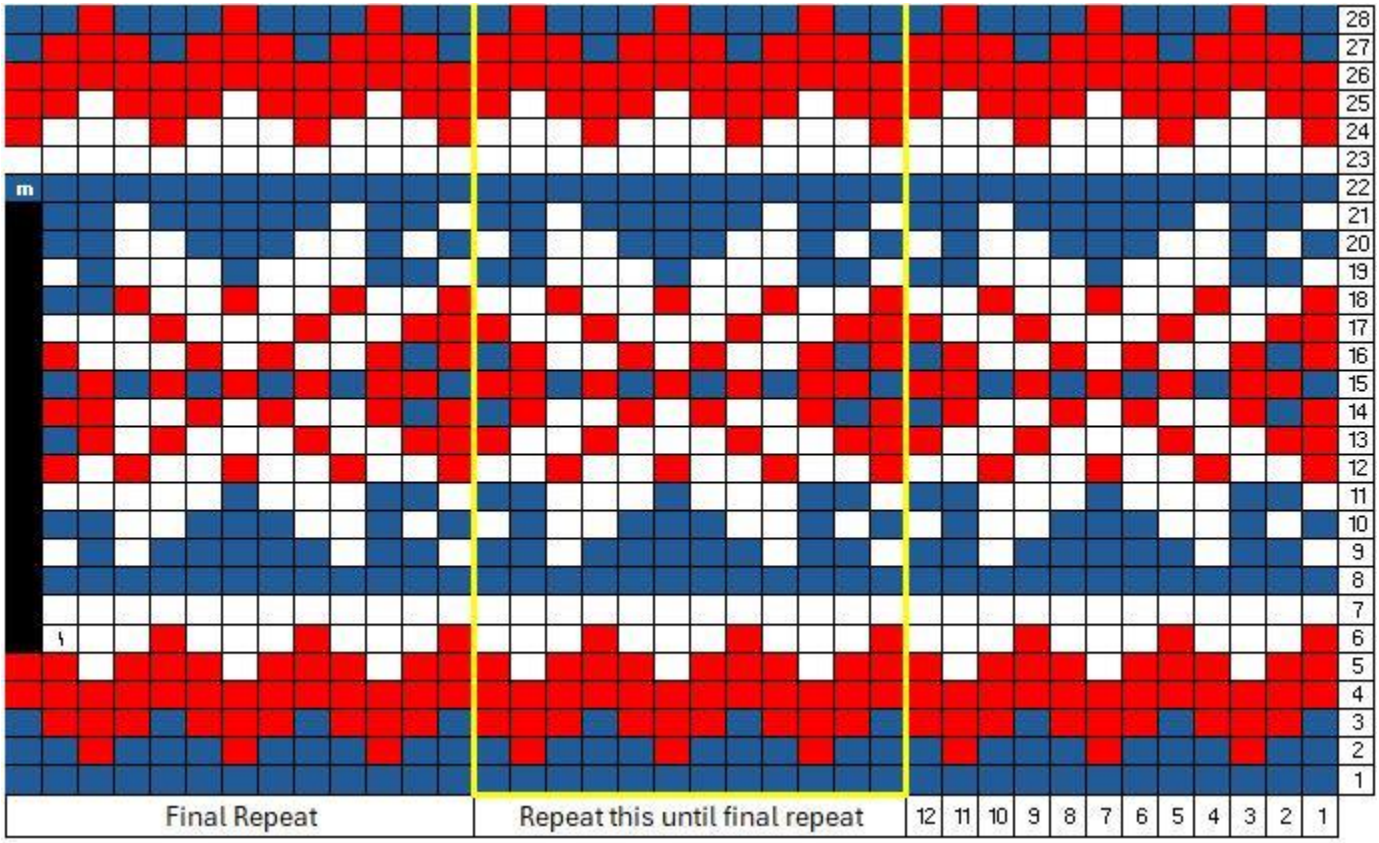
How to Make a Tassel

 1. Materials needed.	2. Wrap yarn around small book – 20-30 wraps.	3. Slip double yarn under the wraps – book makes this easier. Tie yarn tightly around wraps.
4. Cut loops.	5. Turn inside out so that the knot is to the INSIDE. If you are not using twisted cord to attach the tassel, leave knot at top.	6. Fold over and neaten the top.
7. Take a length of yarn and wrap TIGHTLY around tassel, making sure the first end is held securely. Use tapestry needle to secure final end under the wraps.	8. Trim ends neatly.	

Charts

Chart A for Size Small/Medium (8 repeats)

Last repeat stitch count varies from 13 to 12 to 13.



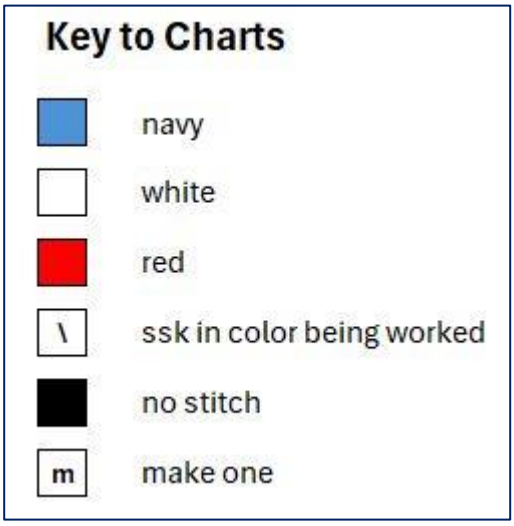


Chart C

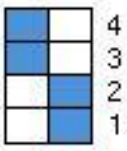
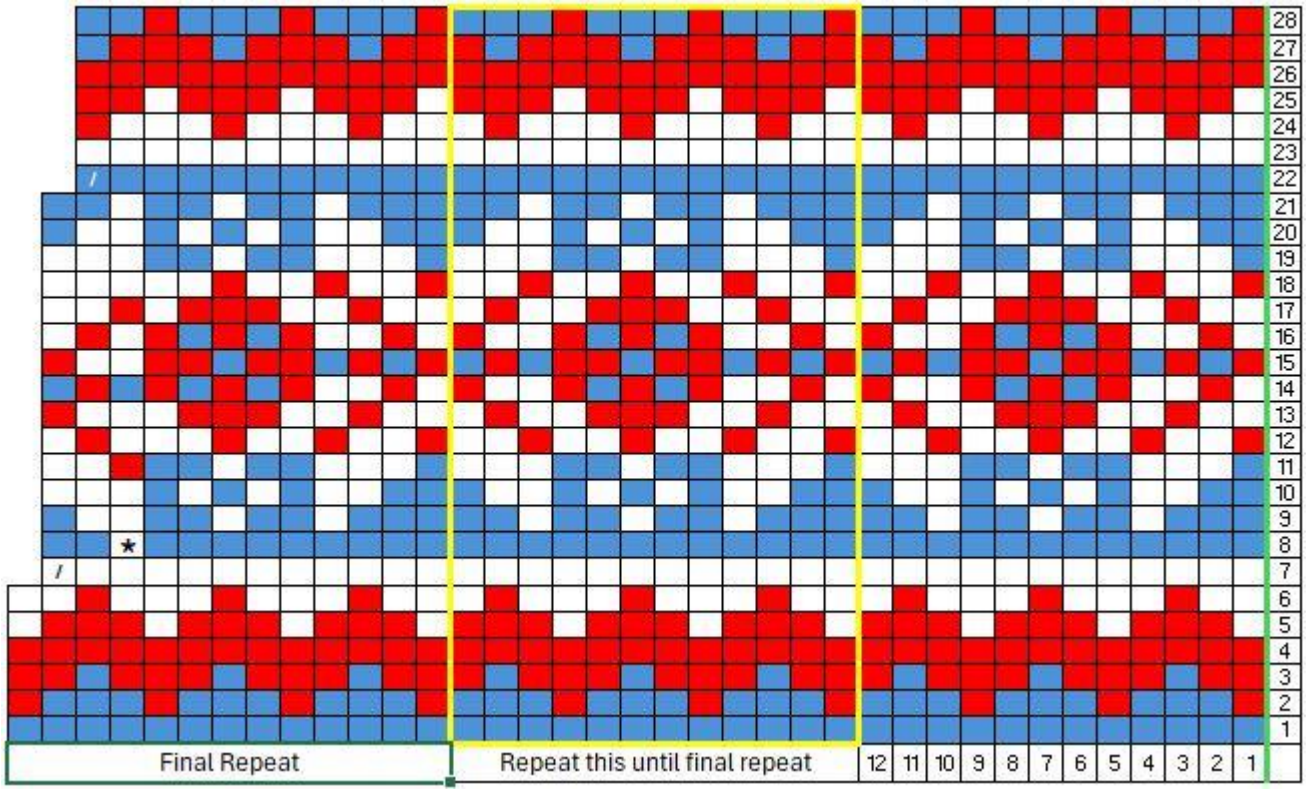


Chart B for Size Large/Extra Large (9 repeats)

Last repeat stitch count varies from 13 to 12 to 11.



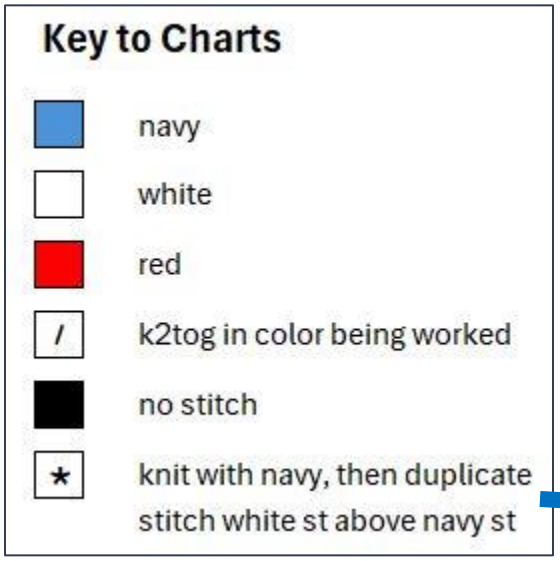
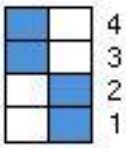
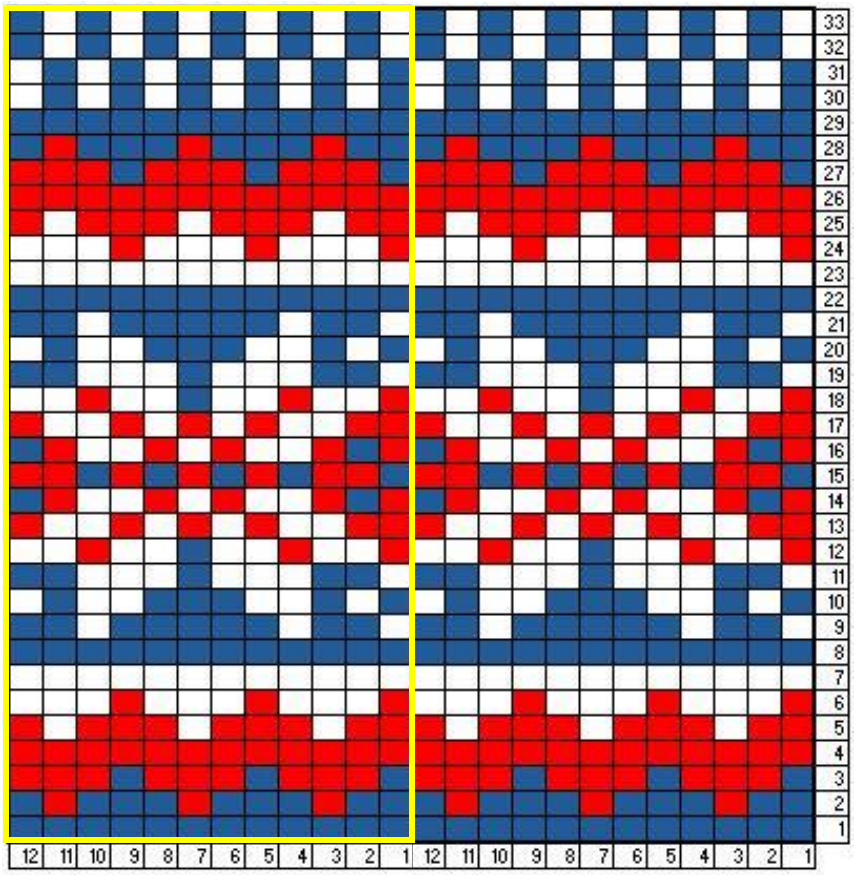


Chart C



Men's Polo Ralph Lauren Team USA Opening Ceremony Earflap Hat

The original hat was knit top down and seamed at the back and the crown. Obviously, it also has the official patch. The original retail price is $328.

Original Chart with 3-Color Rounds